Referee Abuse Prevention Policy

THE NEED FOR CHANGE

RESPECT THE CALL

Referee abuse is an issue on the rise - one that threatens the future of soccer.

90% of referees report that abuse has increased over the last 5 years.

60% of referees choose not to recertify due to harassment and threats.

Youth soccer needs referees to grow - without them, games can't happen

Source: U.S. Soccer Refereeing Department

Referee Abuse Prevention

- **Working group is developing a universal reporting tool for Referee Abuse (est. Fall 2026)**
- **Process for any referee abuse is for the local region/area to conduct the review and issue the sanction**
  - **Report final decisions to the NRPA (email) – Include Misconduct/Incident report and disciplinary action**
  - **Note that any incident reports must also go to Risk Management**

Reporting and disciplinary action are important to preventing Referee Abuse!

Updates to Laws of the Game

(25/26 Law Changes, 26/27 Law Changes)

Law 3: The Players

Law 3.10 (Team captain), guidelines have been introduced into the Laws for any competitions wishing to apply the principle of only the captain approaching the referee in specific situations.

AYSO will not require communication with the referee to only be made by the Captain(s)

Law 3: The Players (Cont'd)

Time-limited substitutions

- To further streamline match flow, substituted players must leave the field of play within ten seconds of the referee's signal. Should the player fail to leave within this time, they must still exit the field but the substitute will not be permitted to enter until the first stoppage after one minute (running clock) has elapsed following the restart.

This applies to Monitored Substitutions

Law 3: The Players (Cont'd)

Off-field treatment and assessment

- Where a player other than the Goalkeeper receives on-field assessment for an injury, or their injury causes play to be stopped, the player will be required to leave the field of play and remain off it for one minute (running clock) once play has restarted.

Used to be the player could reenter with the referee's permission as soon as play restarted

Law 4: The Player's Equipment

Non-dangerous items will be permitted if safely and securely covered.

For AYSO, jewelry will continue to be considered dangerous.

Law 8: The Start and Restart of Play

Law 8.2 (Dropped ball): If the ball is outside the penalty area when play is stopped, it is dropped for the team that had or would have gained possession if this is clear to the referee; otherwise, it is dropped for the team that last touched it. The ball is dropped at its position when play was stopped

Law 9: The Ball in and out of Play

Law 9.2 (Ball in play): An indirect free kick with no disciplinary sanction will be awarded if a team official, substitute, substituted or sent-off player or player who is temporarily off the field of play touches the ball as it is leaving the field of play and there was no intention to interfere unfairly

Law 12: Fouls and Misconduct (Cont'd)

Law 12.2 (Indirect free kick). If a goalkeeper holds the ball for longer than eight seconds (with the referee using a visual five-second countdown), the referee will award a corner kick to the opposing team (rather than the current indirect free kick for more than six seconds).

Please use your voice to encourage the keeper to put the ball back into play

Law 12: Fouls and Misconduct

Where the referee applies the advantage for an offence that would have been deemed to be denying an obvious goal-scoring opportunity, the offending player will not be cautioned if a goal is scored, as the offence did not prevent a goal.

Law 15 & 16: Throw-Ins and Goal Kicks

- If the referee considers that a throw-in or goal kick is taking too long or being deliberately delayed, a five-second visual countdown will be initiated.
- If the ball is not in play at the end of the countdown, the throw-in will be awarded to the opposing team.
- A delayed goal kick will result in a corner kick being awarded to the opponents.

Please use your voice to encourage the players to put the ball back into play

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